CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BARISTA (CRAFT COFFEE) IN THE AI ERA

The craft is real — latte art, extraction, dialled-in grinders. The pay structure never got the memo: this is a minimum-wage-anchored counter job wearing an apron of expertise.

★ TL;DR — NO. There is no BLS occupation called Barista; the anchor is Fast Food and Counter Workers at $31,200 a year (BLS, May 2025). The old card's $45K sits above the anchor group's entire 90th percentile (□$43K annualised) — top-decile counter money sold as typical. The craft premium is real but tiny in dollars, part-time hours are common, and there is no pay ladder inside the barista job itself: the only way up is leaving the title. This roadmap points the coffee years at the seats that do pay. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

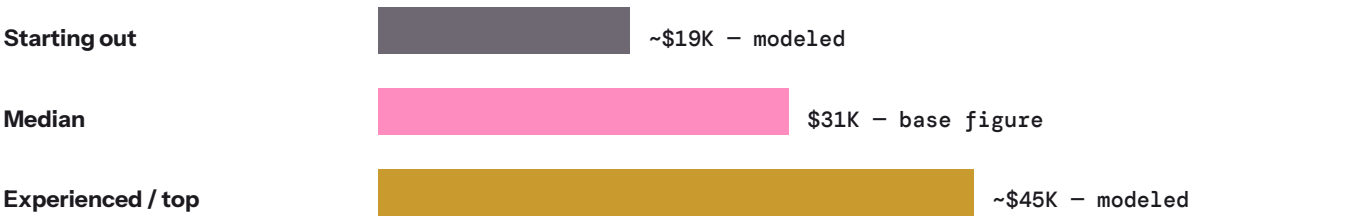
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$31K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Fails as a start because: the beginner's job pays the counter-worker median of $15.00/hr (~$31K full-time equivalent), and no rung inside the title converts craft skill into $45K.
- The automation story is backwards: Starbucks publicly reversed its automation-for-labour swap in 2025 and put $500M+ into more worker hours — demand is not the problem; the wage floor is.
- The quiet threat is deskilling: super-automatic espresso machines are marketed precisely for 'non-specialist staff and even self-serve', removing the skill premium a craft career would charge for.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Barista (craft coffee) is a ~$31K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BARISTA (CRAFT COFFEE) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Pull espresso, steam milk and build drinks to a café's spec
- ✓ Run the counter: orders, register, payment, handoff
- ✓ Dial in grinders, clean machines, restock the bar
- ✓ Hold speed and warmth through the morning rush

Think: a short-order bartender for the sober morning crowd — same theatre, fraction of the tips.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Robotic baristas retreated to niches: Cafe X closed its downtown San Francisco cafés in 2020 and survives at airports; Briggo became Costa's BaristaBot with no scale rollout. Inside real cafés, super-automatic machines deskill the craft steps rather than removing the worker.	Regulars, rush-hour triage, the drink made right for the person in front of you — hospitality at counter scale. It is also, on its own, not a ladder.

⚠ **Even the premium chain does not rescue the figure: Starbucks states its baristas average over $19/hr in cash pay across tenured staff — □$40K annualised, still below the old card's $45K, and that is an average including veterans, not a starting wage. Part-time scheduling means many beginners take home less than the full-time-equivalent median.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Work is abundant: the anchor group posts ~827,400 openings a year ✓ Zero gate: no credential, hired and trained in days to weeks ✓ Coffee skill and regulars are real assets — for the café and management doors	✗ Median $31,200, set by minimum-wage floors, tips a supplement not a salary ✗ No internal pay ladder — supervisor and manager are different jobs, in different roadmaps ✗ The biggest chain closed 627 stores in its September 2025 restructuring round

Good fit? You want income now and a hospitality ladder next — and you'll treat the bar as base camp, not base pay.
Bad fit? You planned to build a career on craft coffee pay alone, or priced your life against $45K.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Caterer
The ladder your counter years already feed: Food Service Managers median $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, formal requirement a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience. The printed rungs: floor ~$35K → first-line supervisor $45,370 → manager $69,390. Coffee shops run on exactly your skills — speed, regulars, morning P&L.; First move: take the shift-lead keys in your current café and own the morning numbers.	The event side of coffee and food: catering companies hire beginners immediately, and a permitted catering business is legally openable in year one — coffee and brunch service is one of the easiest event formats to sell. Labelled anchor: Food Service Managers $69,390 (+6%). First move: price a coffee-and-pastry package for small events and pitch it to two local venues or planners.

Smart move: Become the barista who can run the morning alone — open, dial in, bank, close. That is a supervisor's résumé written in café language, and it is the only version of this job that promotes.
Where you land after: You land supervising or managing the kind of operation you used to staff — at the $69,390 anchor — or selling event coffee under your own permit.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	TAKE THE	PICK YOUR	OWN A	STACK THE	MOVE BEFORE

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS Food and Beverage Serving page: counter-worker median $15.00/hr / $31,200
- Do the honest math on your likely schedule — part-time hours cut the take-home below that figure

STEP 2 — Take the counter job as a platform

WEEKS 1–2

- Choose the busiest well-run café you can — volume teaches speed, and speed is what supervisors are made of
- Learn the whole station set: register, bar, open, close

STEP 3 — Pick your door MONTH 1

- Door A if you want the salaried ladder: shift lead, then supervisor, then manager
- Door B if you want your own book: event coffee and catering packages

STEP 4 — Own a number MONTHS 1-3

- Morning sales, waste, or ticket times — track one and improve it visibly
- Ask for the keys: opening and closing duties are the formal start of the ladder

STEP 5 — Stack the event proof (Door B) or the lead title (Door A) MONTHS 3-6

- Door A: hold a shift-lead title in writing; it is what manager postings ask for
- Door B: run two paid coffee-service events and collect photos and references

STEP 6 — Move before the wage floor becomes the ceiling MONTH 6-12

- Apply to supervisor/assistant-manager postings inside or outside your chain
- If neither door has moved by month 12, the counter has given you all it has — change employers, not effort

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: read the BLS counter-worker wage line and price your real schedule against it.
- Days 1–30: hired at a high-volume café; door chosen; full station set learned.
- Days 31–60: owning a morning number; key-holder duties started.
- Days 61–90: shift-lead title or first paid event coffee service completed.
- Day 90: the bar is funding your climb instead of defining your pay.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **PULL SHOTS. CLIMB ANYWAY.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.